

Magic bowls were typically inscribed not only with quotes from the Quran, but also with magic signs from Persia or even China, alongside symbols of the zodiac and of the planets. Many had figures of beasts such as scorpions and snakes, too.

Scholars of the occult

Magic in the early Islamic world was not just workaday; the translation work spurred serious scholarly interest. Scholars distinguished between *sihr* (magic) and *kihana* (divination), but these categories overlapped.

For some, *sihr* comprised only conjuring tricks such as swallowing swords. The 10th-century lawyer Abu Bakr al-Jassas insisted that belief in magic was simply

ignorance. But for many *sihr* was a true occult power able to summon jinns or even bring the dead back to life. The most famous scholar of magic was the 12th-century author Ahmad ibn Ali al-Buni. In *Luma'at al-nuraniyya* ("Brilliant Lights") he looked into the occult properties of the 99 names of God and advised how amulets could harness the names' supernatural power.

Magic writing

For many early followers of Islam, letters and numbers had magical powers, and some magicians became highly skilled in 'ilm al-huruf, the science of letters. This involved studying the occult properties of Arabic letters and their associated names. In one method of divination called onomancy, a number was first assigned to each letter of a particular name or phrase. Then the numerical value

▼ Dot divination

Early geomancers looked for patterns in tossed handfuls of earth. However, by the 12th century, diviners could turn the dials on an instrument such as this to make a random pattern of dots, which they then interpreted.

